

Richard Kelsey BCom, PGDipBA

Ecommerce and AI consultant for Australian online retailers

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Ecommerce and AI consultant with 16+ years scaling ecommerce operations from startup to category leader and successful exit. I help online retailers grow their stores and put AI to work where it pays: ecommerce growth strategy, customer acquisition, platform and email decisions, and practical AI for marketing and operations. Experienced operating at board level, managing complex stakeholder environments and delivering enterprise-scale platform transformations. Available for consulting, or a full or part time engagement where the fit is right.

KEY ACHIEVEMENTS

- Built Beer Cartel from startup in a storage shed to high 7-figure annual revenue and successful exit
- Achieved 250% conversion increase during peak through UX improvements and checkout optimisation
- Generated \$1M in four days with Beer Advent Calendar through multi-channel marketing campaign
- Delivered BigCommerce to Shopify migration in 90 days with zero downtime and \$100K savings
- Scaled email marketing to 30% of revenue through behaviour-based segmentation and lifecycle triggers
- Generated \$100k annual revenue and built industry authority through 10-minute Australian Craft Beer Survey
- Delivered 5:1 ROAS versus 3.5:1 industry average through hands-on optimisation of high six-figure marketing budget across Meta and Google
- Raised \$1.5m equity on a \$60k marketing budget
- Optimised marketing and fulfilment technology stacks to support 300% overnight growth during Covid and keep next day dispatch promise
- Kept a 4.8 Google rating when Australia Post delayed 2,000+ parcels by 30 days during Covid
- Elected Board Member of Retail Drinks Australia, alongside C-level executives from major liquor retailers
- Top 50 People in Australian Ecommerce (3x) | Best Online Retail Marketing (ORIAS) | Retail Innovation Winner

EXPERTISE

Ecommerce Operations & Strategy

- Developing and executing eCommerce strategies aligned with business objectives; product management, pricing strategy, promotional cadence, UX optimisation
- P&L management, trade forecasting, budgeting, and performance analysis
- Conversion rate optimisation through systematic testing, data-driven insights, and customer journey analysis

Marketing & Customer Acquisition

- Integrated marketing strategy across paid acquisition, organic growth, and retention programmes
- Customer segmentation, lifecycle marketing, and performance optimisation informed by data analysis

Leadership & Governance

- Leading cross-functional teams across purchasing, operations, finance, and marketing with vendor management and stakeholder coordination
- Board-level experience with C-level executives, strategic planning, framework development, and commercial decision-making

Technology, AI & Platform Management

- Complex tech ecosystems: payment gateways, marketplace integrations, CRM, ERP, marketing automation, fulfilment, AI/LLMs, and subscriptions
- Enterprise-scale end-to-end platform migrations with focus on zero downtime and cost efficiency

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

May 2026 – Present | Independent Consultant, Digital Marketing and AI Strategy

- Ecommerce growth strategy, customer acquisition planning and practical AI implementation for marketing and operations
- Fixed-price audits (AI search readiness, ecommerce and AI growth), a two-week AI Strategy Sprint, and monthly consulting
- Hands-on builder: a personal agent system on the Claude API that handles parts of my daily work
- Co-founder, Made 4 Tradies: websites for Australian trade businesses

January 2009 – September 2025 | CEO & Director | Beer Cartel

Co-founded and built Australia's #1 online craft beer store. Started as a two-person operation in 2009 based out of a Kennards Storage Shed, pioneering alcohol ecommerce in Australia. Grew business to 12 permanent employees and 15 casual staff during peak periods, leasing commercial premises and warehouse on Sydney's North Shore. Scaled to high 7-figure revenue and successful exit in 2024.

Whilst Director of the business (and acting Head of Ecommerce and CMO), adopted a corporate structure to ensure professional operation. Had four direct reports: Marketing Manager, Procurement Manager, Operations Manager, and Finance Manager. Reported to the board of directors which comprised of the two co-founders and an external finance expert, presenting quarterly on financial performance, strategic initiatives, and capital requirements. Implemented annual budgeting process with quarterly reviews and board reporting cadence. Moved to CEO role following the sale of the business.

Growth & Performance

- Owned end-to-end ecommerce operations including site merchandising, product management, pricing strategy, and UX optimisation, growing revenue from \$0 to high 7-figure whilst maintaining profitability
- Increased conversion rate 250% during peak periods through systematic CRO initiatives including UX optimisation, checkout flow improvements, and feature implementation
- Improved customer lifetime value by 55% through retention strategies and subscription offerings
- Achieved 5:1 ROAS on paid media across Meta and Google Shopping/Search whilst managing high six-figure annual marketing budget
- Launched Beer Advent Calendar generating \$1M revenue in 4 days through integrated campaign across onsite optimisations, paid (Google/Meta), social, email marketing, influencer partnerships, affiliates and PR

Leadership & Corporate Development

- Built and led cross-functional organisation across four departments: Purchasing, Operations, Finance, and Marketing
- Managed P&L, financial planning, forecasting, and budget management across all business functions
- Scaled team from two founders at startup to 30+, including managing 300% sales volume increase during COVID-19, developing internal leaders and maintaining culture
- Raised \$1.5M equity through crowdsource funding (1,150 shareholders), secured \$150K+ in government grants
- Executed M&A: Acquired Brewquets & Unifor, successfully divested Unifor

Customer Acquisition & Retention

- Built customer database from 0 to 150,000+ through integrated strategy across paid acquisition (Meta, Google), organic growth (SEO, content, PR), conversion optimisation, retention (email, SMS), and partnerships
- Developed email marketing engine generating 30% of total revenue through advanced segmentation strategies
- Created and scaled subscription offering to 10% of revenue improving average subscription length by 57%
- Increased average order value by 25% through product pricing strategy review, site optimisation and driving upsells

Brand Building & Marketing Leadership

- Directed integrated marketing strategy across paid acquisition, organic channels, and retention programmes
- Established Beer Cartel as Australia's craft beer authority through award-winning Australian Craft Beer Survey, which built significant organic brand awareness, media attention, customer database and sales growth
- Built strategic partnerships with craft breweries across Australia, developing relationships beyond traditional supplier-buyer arrangements
- Directed all PR and media relations initiatives, securing coverage across broadcast, podcast, and digital news platforms

- Managed vendor relationships across web development, SEO, and marketing agencies to ensure optimal performance and ROI
- Deployed AI tools for marketing content creation and product descriptions, reducing copy error rates and improving conversion
- Implemented marketing automations to drive additional revenue

Technology & AI Implementation

- Managed marketing technology stack and led vendor selection for marketing automation, CRM, customer support systems, inventory management/ERP, and marketplace integrations
- Led enterprise-scale platform selection, implementation, and migration projects (5), including BigCommerce to Shopify transformation, delivering \$100K cost savings whilst maintaining zero downtime
- Integrated payment gateway ecosystem including digital wallets and BNPL solutions
- Directed subscription management infrastructure and logistics

Brewquets

- Acquired B2C and B2B gift delivery business scaling from \$170K to \$1M+ annual revenue (6X growth) through integrated digital marketing strategy across paid media (Google/Meta), SEO, email, and social channels
- Optimised Brewquets Shopify platform including merchandising, UX improvements, and marketing automation
- Drove 200% increase in Valentine's Day sales and 500% increase in Father's Day and Christmas sales through integrated digital marketing campaigns

Awards

- Top 50 People in Australian Ecommerce 3x Winner
- Online Retailer of the Year, Beer & Brewer Magazine 5x Winner
- Best Online Retail Marketing, Australia Post Online Retail Industry Awards (ORIAS)
- Retail Innovator of the Year, ARA Australian Retail Awards
- BigCommerce Make It Big Innovation Award 2x Winner

November 2019 – September 2025 | Board Member | Retail Drinks Australia

Elected board member representing digital & online liquor retailers for national industry body supporting 6,500+ member businesses.

- Shaped advocacy agenda and strategy for retail liquor industry alongside C-level executives from Australia's largest retailers including Coles, Endeavour (Woolworths) and Metcash
- Provided guidance for Online Code of Conduct, establishing framework for retailing alcohol in legislated environment
- Guided organisational mission and provided strategic direction at board level
- Represented and advocated for digital retail category across national policy discussions

January 2008 – April 2013 | Consultant | BDRC Jones Donald

Boutique market research consultancy serving blue-chip enterprise clients across a range of industries.

- Managed 5+ concurrent client projects (\$50K-\$150K each) including Optus, American Express & Lion
- Presented research findings and strategic recommendations directly to C-level executives
- Managed project teams (internal and external vendors) and coordinated stakeholder relationships across multiple concurrent client engagements

Previous work

(2011 – 2018) Porter's Liquor Artarmon, Owner | (2011 – 2014) Unifor Corporate Supplies, Owner | (2006 – 2008) Colmar Brunton Research, Project Manager | (2005) Asteron Life, Customer Support | (2004) Westpac (NZ), Customer Support

EDUCATION AND TRAINING

Postgraduate Diploma Business Administration | Massey University (NZ)

Bachelor of Commerce (Marketing & Finance) | University of Canterbury (NZ)

Claude Code in Action | Anthropic (March 2026)

Generative AI for business leaders, AI ethics and Microsoft Copilot | Courses (September 2025)

TECHNICAL CAPABILITIES

Ecommerce/CMS Platforms: Shopify Plus • BigCommerce • WordPress • End-to-end Platform Migration Management • CMS Management

Analytics & Optimisation: Google Analytics • Google Search Console • Heat Mapping & CRO Tools (Hotjar, Lucky Orange) • A/B Testing • UX/UI Optimisation • CRO Optimisation • Customer Journey Mapping

Marketing Automation & CRM: Klaviyo • Dotdigital • Mailchimp • Attentive • CDP (Glew) • Customer Segmentation & Lifecycle Marketing • Automated Workflow Development • Marketing Content Automation

Paid Media & Advertising: Google Ads • Meta Ads Manager • Google Shopping/Search • Affiliate Marketing • Partnerships • Influencer Marketing • Online Display Advertising • Multi-Channel Performance Marketing

Payment Ecosystem: Braintree • PayPal • Stripe • eWay • Tyro • SecurePay • Apple Pay • Google Pay • BNPL (Zip, AfterPay)

Marketplaces: Amazon • eBay • Kogan • Catch • Third-Party Channel Management

Operations & Fulfilment: Inventory Management/ERP (Cin7 Core/Dear) • Subscription Management • Customer Support Systems (Gorgias, Reamaze) • Merchandising (Searchspring)

Integration & Automation: Zapier • OrderDesk • API Integration Management • Cross-Platform Data Flow

AI & Development Tools: ChatGPT • Claude • Claude Code • Gemini • Microsoft Copilot • Cursor • Perplexity • Replit

Research & Insights: SurveyMonkey • TypeForm • Data-Driven Decision Making • Consumer Research

Methodologies: Digital Transformation • Performance Marketing • SEO & Organic Growth • Multi-Channel Marketing Strategy • Conversion Rate Optimisation • AOV Optimisation & Upselling Strategies • Customer Segmentation • Product Launch Management • Change Management • Stakeholder Management • Cross-functional Team Leadership • Vendor Management • Platform Migration Management • Merchandising Strategy • Customer Lifecycle Marketing • Retention Marketing • Agile Methodologies